

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



UNLIKELY AID: Ayyubi giving lessons through a movie

Persian Masala Mix

Dubbed Bollywood movies become a source of learning and inspiration for students of Farsi

■ **By Farzand Ahmed**

Almost every day, the chamber of Arif Ayyubi, Head of the Persian Department of Lucknow University, turns into a theatre. Surrounded by students, mostly from Afghanistan, Ayyubi, 42, puts in a dubbed-in-Persian Hindi movie DVD in his computer and says politely, "*Agha-yun va Khanuum-ha; Khasta nabasheed, dasht-e-dard na kun-e; lutfun be navist; lutfun takrar kuneed; takrar be-farid* (dear all, if you are not feeling tired; if your hands are comfortable then please write and repeat the dialogues aloud)." Thus begins a unique class of teaching a language with the aid of movies.

Ayyubi says there are four basics for learning a foreign language—listening, watching, reading or writing—but neither of these help a student master the diction or pronunciation. His challenge was to combine all four in an interesting manner and a most unlikely source, dubbed Bollywood movies, came to his rescue. His class of 48 has 24 Afghan students along with 24 Indians, including five girls, who now speak Persian in a rather theatrical style.

The idea of using the unusual teaching aid occurred to him during one of his visits to Tehran where he was surprised to find pirated DVDs of Indian movies, including south Indian



films, that reached Iran much before their release in India. Ayyubi started collecting the dubbed movies and found these to be a hit with students. Afghan student Sheer Ul Sultanat says: "Using movies for learning a language is useful as we can master the pronunciation and understand culture also. This innovation of the Persian Department is very useful." Ayyubi,

with a collection of over 90 DVDs, says Persian is written and spoken differently which makes it difficult to master. Dubbed dialogues help students learn the correct pronunciation.

Students don't go by the story but by actors. Amitabh Bachchan, Sunil Shetty and Kareena Kapoor seem to be hot favourites. Students like the dialogues and songs that are dubbed in Persian. They also keep a look-out for similarities in culture, lifestyle and architecture. Ayyubi has now installed a dish to capture Iranian television serials and news telecasts to help his students improve their language further.

An estimated 11 crore people worldwide speak Persian though the language is in a decline. Lucknow has an emotional attachment to the language as rulers from the Nawabi era hailed from Iran. Even now many scholars visit Iran for higher studies. "If etiquette and culture exist in Lucknow, it is because of Urdu and Persian—one of the richest languages," says Ayyubi with a tinge of nostalgia. ■